

At Papa's in Mumbai, the intimate 12-seat chef's counter experience by Hunger Inc. Hospitality has become one of the city's most difficult reservations

Back in Mumbai, Papa's, the intimate 12-seat chef's counter experience by Hunger Inc. Hospitality, has become one of the city's most difficult reservations, with seats snapped up within minutes of bookings opening. The restaurant, led by chef Hussain Shahzad, offers a 12-course vegetarian or non-vegetarian tasting menu priced at ₹8,000 per person, excluding taxes and beverages. Despite the premium pricing, demand far exceeds its limited capacity of approximately 200 covers a month. Yash Bhanage, founder and COO of Hunger Inc., says guests include younger diners and people travelling from other cities specifically for the meal. Designed to resemble an intimate dinner party rather than a conventional restaurant visit, Papa's places considerable emphasis on personal attention over the three-hour experience. "I wouldn't describe that as exclusivity. We did not create 12 seats to keep people out; we created them so we could really look after the people who come in," says Bhanage.

It is an important distinction. While scarcity undoubtedly adds to the desirability of these restaurants, their operators argue that the real attraction must remain the quality and individuality of the experience.

The numbers indicate that this appetite for premium dining is part of a larger shift in India's food services industry. According to estimates by Frost & Sullivan, based on data from the National Restaurant Association of India (NRAI), the country's fine-dining market was valued at approximately ₹5,100 crore in FY2024 and is projected to reach ₹8,300 crore by FY2028, growing at a compound annual growth rate of around 13%. While ultra-premium tasting menus and exclusive chef-led experiences represent a relatively small niche within this industry, their growing popularity points to a consumer willing to spend considerably more on distinctive culinary experiences.

Probably the clearest indication of India's changing appetite for high-end dining is the arrival of Raga in New Delhi.

Opened at the end of August, at Janpath in the former Masala Library space, Raga marks celebrated chef Gaggan Anand's much-anticipated entry into India's restaurant market. Created with restaurateur Zorawar Kalra and chef Rydo Anton, the restaurant offers an elaborate 22-course tasting menu priced at ₹11,111 plus taxes per person.

For Kalra, the decision to bring Anand (whose restaurant Gaggan in Bangkok holds two Michelin stars) to India was driven by a belief that the market was finally ready for an ambitious, internationally benchmarked dining experience.

He was proven right. Raga's reservation website crashed within minutes of bookings opening, overwhelmed by demand. Reservations quickly stretched weeks ahead. Kalra says bookings have extended into the following year now.

"We are the most premium restaurant in India at the moment, but that's because of the sheer amount of effort, technique and creativity that goes into the food," Kalra says.

Raga's response has strengthened the case for more restaurants operating in the ₹7,000-15,000 per person category. After all, for a growing group of Indians, an expensive meal is no longer simply a display of extravagance; it is an experience worth planning, travelling, and saving for. BT